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Between national and local: Identity representations of post-colonial Hong Kong in a local English newspaper

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ABSTRACT

This study gives a corpus-assisted discourse study of the representations of Hong Kong identity with identity labels in a Hong Kong English newspaper (i.e., the *South China Morning Post*) in the last two decades. It not only identifies the various labels used for the concerned parties, but also examines their varied use in the changing social political context and the ideologies behind the choice of some prominent identity labels. The finding suggests that the newspaper prefers to choose labels that foreground the local identity of Hong Kong rather than its national identification. This trend has become particularly evident since 2003 and the constructions of Hong Kong identity have become increasingly negative in the last few years.

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1. Introduction

This study addresses the discursive constructions of group or collective identities in a unique socio-political context, i.e., the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (HKSAR). As a former British colony, Hong Kong's identities have arisen to be one of the top concerns for people in Hong Kong since the signing of the Sino-Britain Joint Declaration in 1984 (Flowerdew, 2004). Even though the Basic Law promises that Hong Kong would keep its own legal and economic systems unchanged for at least 50 years, there have been constant worries about whether Hong Kong could maintain its unique identity under Chinese sovereignty (Cheng and Lam, 2013). The growing economic integration of Hong Kong with China and political conflicts in recent years have further exacerbated Hong Kong's identity concerns. Just 22 years after the handover, "there is probably no saga that better encapsulates Hong Kong's delicate situation as well as its relations with the central government" (Cabestan and Florence, 2018, p. 3). This can be seen from the ongoing protests against the proposed extradition bill in Hong Kong at the time of writing this article.

This study gives an extensive examination of the discursive constructions of Hong Kong identity during the last two decades in a local Hong Kong English newspaper, i.e., *South China Morning Post* (SCMP). Since the introduction of national identity as an "imagined community" (Anderson, 1983), national identities, or collective identities in general, have been understood as basically a discursive phenomenon (Wodak, 2012). They are "socially construed, discursively mediated, dynamic, context-dependent and relational" (Zotzmann and O'Regan, 2016, p. 123). Founded in 1903, SCMP is "a newspaper of record" in Hong Kong. It has enjoyed a relatively stable circulation in Hong Kong for years and known for its elite readership and liberal stance (Cheng and Lam, 2010). Nevertheless, there have been constant concerns over its editorial independence and self-censorship due to its recent ownership changes, i.e., its acquirement by a Malaysian business tycoon Robert Kuok in 1993 and a Chinese Business tycoon Jack Ma in 2015. While previous studies suggest that SCMP tends to align with the government in representing certain issues (Flowerdew et al., 2002), there is still little information about how it interacted with the changing socio-political contexts in the constructions of the Hong Kong identity during the last two decades. The following sections first give a brief introduction of the research background, the relations between language, identity, and ideology as well as the methodology used.

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Then the findings will be presented before a summary of the main ideas and their implications.

2. The rise of the Hong Kong identity: history, conflict, and crisis

The development of Hong Kong identity is intertwined with its origin as a Chinese land and its history as a former British colony. It "embodies and manifests both cultural affiliation with and resistance to Chinese identity" (Fung and Chan, 2017, p. 3). As a Chinese land, Hong Kong was relinquished to British colonial control due to the unequal treaties signed after the two Opium Wars (Flowerdew, 2012). Even though the majority of its inhabitants were migrants from the Chinese mainland, a distinct Hong Kong identity *Heungongyahn* (i.e.,"Hong Kong people") began to emerge in the 1970s due to the restraint on the free movement and the widening economic gap between the Chinese mainland and Hong Kong in the 1960s and 1970s (Chan, 2014). While Hong Kong residents still identified themselves as Chinese in the ethnic and racial sense, they viewed themselves as different from Chinese mentally. This new Hong Kong identity has thus been defined variously as "Chineseness plus", "market-based identity, and "liberal patriotism" (Veg, 2017). By the 1980s, the new Hong Kong identity had been widely accepted (Lau, 1997).

While some researchers (Mathews, 1997) predicted before the handover that Hong Kong people's identification with the Chinese nation would increase after the handover, especially among young people born after the handover (Veg, 2017), the building of a Chinese national identity has been confronted with constant resistance since Hong Kong's return to China in 1997 (Chan, 2014). It dampened the Hong Kong government's early attempts to strengthen Hong Kong's political and ethnic ties with China in the first five years, and even resulted in the massive demonstration against the legislation of the National Security Ordinance in 2003. It forced the Chinese government to change its laisse-faire policy to a more interventionist approach in Hong Kong. A series of socio-economic policies have been introduced in the following years to strengthen the integration of Hong Kong with the Chinese mainland, including the free trade deal of the Closer Economic Partnership Arrangement (CEPA) and the Individual Visit Scheme (IVS). These policies helped Hong Kong recover from its economic slump caused by the severe acute aspiratory syndrome (SARS) epidemic. The following years from 2003 to 2009, therefore, saw a stable rise in Hong Kong people's identification with the Chinese nation. Meanwhile, Hong Kong has also "increasingly asserted itself as a civic and cultural community" (Veg, 2017, p. 325), as can be seen from the patriotism debate (2003–2004), and the campaigns for cultural heritage protection (2004–2010).

The social conflicts between Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland have further aggravated their cultural divergence since 2010 (Chan, 2014). Due to the implementation of IVS, Hong Kong has witnessed the dramatic increase of visitors from the Chinese mainland. It affected the daily life of Hong Kong, and resulted in the growing conflicts between Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland, as can be seen from the protests against mainland women seeking to give birth in Hong Kong in 2011, the resistance movement against plans for national education in secondary schools in 2012, the protests against the delay of Universal Suffrage and the Umbrella Movement in 2014 (Veg, 2017). A recent poll by the Public Opinion Program of the University of Hong Kong (HKUPOP) in December 2018 found that 40.0% of Hong Kong locals called themselves "Hong Konger" (香港人), 26.3% as "Hong Konger in China" (中国的香港人), 16.9% as "Chinese in Hong Kong" (香港的中国人), 15.1% as "Chinese" (中国人), 43.2% as "mixed identity" (混合身份). It captures the intricate picture of Hong Kong people's identities.

3. Language, identity and ideology

This study examines a key discursive strategy for identity constructions, i.e., labeling or naming. An integral part of imagining a nation is to propose an identity label (Galasiński and Skowronek, 2001), because without a name national or collective identities can only exist as a desire (Joseph, 2004, p. 5). Identity labels can be realized through these referential expressions used to address a particular group of people. They can "put invisible boundaries for human perception and suggests attitudes for its evaluation" (Kiewe, 1998, p. 81). Each identity label or referential expression thus carries "sets of norms, values, premises, and beliefs about the world" (Van Zomeren, 2011). The selection of one label over the others is not arbitrary, but socio-politically conditioned (Chang and Holt, 2009). It can help to construct a certain version of reality and serve important ideological functions (Galasiński and Skowronek, 2001). In addition, the choice of identity labels is also subject to the changing socio-political contexts (Van Zomeren, 2011).

In post-1997 Hong Kong, at the core of Hong Kong identity formation is how Hong Kong people define themselves and their relations to the Chinese mainland. This can be revealed in how they refer to Hong Kong, themselves and those people from the Chinese mainland. Although different labels have been proposed to address the concerned parties, the selection and reproduction of these labels can shed light on the newspaper's political stance and ownership. This has been demonstrated in Zhang and Mihelj's (2012) examination of the use of identity labels in the coverage of the 2005 Hong Kong Chief Executive election by newspapers with different political orientations in Hong Kong. However, Zhang and Mihelj (2012) only focused on Chinese-language newspapers in Hong Kong and did not address the intricate situations in the choice of identity labels in English-language newspapers, because the single Chinese label *Heungongyahn* (香港人) may have several English equivalents, such as *Hong Kong people*, *Hongkonger*, *Hongkongese*, and *Hong Kong person*. These English labels may carry different ideological implicatures in their specific contexts of use. As Freake et al. (2011) demonstrate, two equivalent labels *Quebec* and *Québécois* in English and French newspapers may serve different functions in identity formation: the French label tends to present Quebec in terms of "nationhood and statehood" (p. 32), while the English label suggests alignment with "federalist discourse" in "emphasizing Quebec's relationship with Canada" (p. 41). Zhang and Mihelj (2012) also underlined the significance of a following diachronic study of the use of identity labels in Hong Kong news media. This study is going to give a corpus-assisted discourse study (CADS) of the use of identity labels in SCMP from 1998 to 2017 (Baker et al., 2008; Partington, 2004). It has three objectives: (1) to identify the labels used in the newspaper; (2) to demonstrate how they interacted with the changing socio-political contexts; (3) to expose how they contributed to positive self-presentations and negative other-presentations.

4. Methodology

Viewing discourse as a social practice, critical discourse analysis (CDA) has been known for its interest in explicating the dynamic relations between language and society and its emphasis on the contextualized study of language use, power and ideology (Wodak and Meyer, 2016). Given the indispensable role of news media in "imagining" a nation or a group (Anderson, 1983), CDA is concerned with how media discourse contributes to its "re/production, perpetuation, justification, transformation or destruction" (Wodak, 2018, p. 408). Adopting a CDA approach, this study examines not only the various ways of using identity labels in

the construction of Hong Kong identities but also the changing socio-political contexts and ideologies behind their particular ways of identity constructions (Fairclough, 1992).

Corpus linguistics (CL) is "an empirical method of linguistic analysis and description, which uses corpora as the primary data and starting point" (W. Cheng and Lam, 2010, p. 508). The benefits of using CL methods in CDA have been widely discussed and acknowledged in the last two decades, such as providing the efficient analysis of large data, reducing researcher bias, and enhancing the replicability and thus reliability of the analysis (Baker, 2006; Baker et al., 2008; Mautner, 2009a, 2009b). The availability of the computer-assisted corpus-analytic software makes the efficient processing of a large quantity of data possible. This has been demonstrated in a previous diachronic study on the representations of Hong Kong in a British newspaper (i.e., *The Times*) in the last two decades (Liu and Jiang, 2019). Since this study focuses solely on the use of identity labels, the corpus-analytic software can provide an efficient means for the identification and quantification of identity labels used in SCMP over a time span of twenty years. Additionally, CL methods can also be used to address the "incremental effects" of identity labels in identity construction (Baker et al., 2008). The constitutive effects of these labels can only be accurately assessed through the analysis of a large number of news texts over a long time span. CL methods can also be used to expose significant language patterns which cannot otherwise be identified through mere observation and intuition (Freake et al., 2011). This is especially important in the contextualized analysis of some identity labels.

A large corpus (i.e., SCMP) has been built by collecting all the news reports from SCMP with the term *Hong Kong* in their titles from 1 January 1998 to 30 July 2017. It consists of 9,760,467 tokens with 20 yearly sub-corpora. Viewing identity as a relational concept (Hardt-Mautner, 1995), this study examines the labels for "Hong Kong", "people from Hong Kong", and "people from Chinese mainland". With wordsmith 7.0, we start with an examination of the concordance lines of some tokens (such as *Hong*, *mainland*, and *mainlander*) to identify the different forms of the three groups of identity labels. Then the different forms are further searched in the corpus with a view to identifying the exact number of their occurrences and excluding the irrelevant cases. For example, while *special administrative region* (*SAR*) is identified as a potential label for Hong Kong in the initial analysis, a further examination of the concordance lines of *special administrative region* or *SAR* finds that it also refers to Macao sometimes, so these irrelevant cases are further identified and deducted from the total number of occurrences. Therefore, we keep on moving back and forth from the identification of some potential forms to the examination of their specific contexts of use in order to present an exhaustive list of labels and their exact number of occurrences. However, the labels with only morphic and spelling differences are classified into one type in order to limit the types of identity labels identified. For example, *Hong Kong citizen*, *HK citizen*, *Hong Kong citizen' s*, *Hong Kong citizens*, and *HK citizens* are considered as belonging to the same type of identity label *Hong Kong citizen**. These labels with different words used are classified into different types, e.g., *Hong Kong residents** and *Hong Kong citizen**. Then the actual and standardized (per 1000 words) frequencies of these different types are further computed to identify the newspaper's preferences for the different types of identity labels in each group. It is followed by a calculation of standardized frequencies of each identity label in each sub-corpus with the view of showing the distribution of these identity labels over the twenty years. The results are further discussed in terms of the changing socio-political contexts for the sake of demonstrating the dynamics between media discourse and the socio-political context.

Finally, this study gives a close analysis of three most frequently used lexical items referring to people in the Chinese mainland and Hong Kong, i.e., *Hong Kong people*, *Hongkongers*, and *mainlanders*. It relies primarily on the analysis of collocates of the three lexical items, i.e., those words that frequently co-occur with the three lexical items, with a maximum of four words in-between (Baker et al., 2008). They can reveal the ideologies behind the choice of these identity labels, based on the view that "the meanings of words are constructed and maintained by patterns of collocation" (Romaine, 2001). Collocations can be used to reveal the associations and connotations of words (Stubbs, 1996, p. 172) and distinguish semantically related lexical items (Bogetić, 2013). The verb collocates among the top 150 collocates are first compared to show how they vary in their semantic preferences and semantic prosodies, i.e., "what kinds of social issues a particular item is bound up in, and what attitudes are commonly associated with it" (Mautner, 2016). In addition, this study compares the properties associated with the three lexical items by examining adjective collocates at the first position to the left (i.e., L1 position) of the three lexical items, and the predicate adjectives following the pattern "NOUN + *are*". However, mere collocate analysis is not enough, and other linguistic tools (e.g., transitivity analysis) have also been used to provide a more detailed analysis of verb collocates. Meanwhile, the findings of this study are further discussed in terms of the changing socio-political contexts with a view to exposing who they align with Hong Kong people and/or the Chinese mainland in the constructions of Hong Kong identity.

5. Results and discussion

5.1. Frequencies of identity labels

Table 1 shows the three groups of labels identified. These labels show varied degrees of identification with China and Hong Kong in each group. There are four types of identity labels for "Hong Kong", including *Hong Kong** (149381), *SAR** (7116), *Hong Kong China** (78), and *Chinese Hong Kong* (1). Among them, *Hong Kong** serves a popular label for Hong Kong, which highlights the local identity of Hong Kong but fails to suggest the relations between Hong Kong and China. It is in contrast to *SAR** (i.e., *Hong Kong Special Administrative Region*), an official label for Hong Kong after its return to China. It underlines Hong Kong as a special administrative region of China. The label *Hong Kong China** also elevates the unique status of Hong Kong, because like *Taiwan China* and *mainland China*, it indicates that there may be different Chinas. By contrast, *Chinese Hong Kong** foregrounds Hong Kong as a part of China but downplays the unique status of Hong Kong as a Special Administrative Region of China. While SCMP still shows the dominant use of the popular label *Hong Kong*, it also makes frequent reference to the official label *SAR** after Hong Kong's return to China. However, it refrains from using the two controversial labels *Hong Kong China* and *Chinese Hong Kong*. Especially for *Chinese Hong Kong*, only one occurrence can be identified.

Six identity labels have been identified for "people from the Chinese mainland", including *mainlander** (1511), *mainland Chinese** (169), *mainland resident** (58), *mainland people** (36), *mainland citizen** (19), and *mainland public** (1). The very presence of these labels highlights that people from Chinse mainland is different from people from Hong Kong, thus belonging to an "out" group (Flowerdew et al., 2002). Among them, the lexicalized label *mainlander** is overwhelmingly used to refer to people from Chinese mainland, suggesting that people from Chinese mainland have been conceptualized as an important "other" group which can be labelled solely by the place where they live (Zhang and Mihelj, 2012).

Table 1
The frequencies of referential expressions.

Referent	Labels	Actual freq.	Standardized freq.
Hong Kong	*Hong Kong**	149381	15.30469802
	*SAR**	7116	0.729063476
	*Hong Kong China**	78	0.007991421
	Chinese Hong Kong	1	0.000102454
Mainland people	*Mainlander**	1511	0.154808166
	*Mainland Chinese**	169	0.017314745
	*Mainland resident**	58	0.005942339
	*Mainland people**	36	0.003688348
	*Mainland citizen**	19	0.001946628
	*Mainland public**	1	0.000102454
Hong Kong people	*Hong Kong people**	2085	0.213616828
	*Hongkonger**	1881	0.192716189
	*Hong Kong resident**	767	0.078582306
	*local**	606	0.062087193
	*Hong Kong citizen**	197	0.02018346
	*Hong Kong Chinese**	135	0.013831305
	*Hong Kong public**	110	0.011269953
	*Hong Kong person**	31	0.003176078
	*SAR people**	27	0.002766261
	Hong Kong population	16	0.001639266
	*SAR citizen**	16	0.001639266
	*SAR resident**	13	0.001331903
	Chinese Hong Kong resident	1	0.000307362
	SAR public	1	0.000102454
	Hongkongese	1	0.000102454

All together 15 labels have been identified for "people from Hong Kong". The presence of so many identity labels in fact points to the struggles behind Hong Kong identity construction and the lack of widely accepted labels for people from Hong Kong. Among them, some labels suggest national identification by underlining people from Hong Kong as people from the special administrative region of China, including *SAR people* (27), *SAR citizen* (16), *SAR resident* (13), and *SAR public* (1). However, their overall frequencies are comparatively low. The majority of them underline the unique or local identity of people from Hong Kong, including *Hong Kong people** (2085), *Hongkonger** (1881), *Hong Kong resident** (767), *local** (606), *Hong Kong citizen** (197), *Hong Kong public** (110), *Hong Kong person** (31), and *Hongkongese* (1). Among them, the nominal group *Hong Kong people** is the most popular one. However, another lexicalized label *Hongkonger** is also equally frequently used. As a newly invented identity label, *Hongkonger** has been included in the *Oxford English Dictionary* in 2014 and defined as "a native or an inhabitant of Hong Kong". Similar to the label *mainlander**, it helps to construct people from Hong Kong as a special group of people which can be identified by the place where they live. However, as a global metropolis, Hong Kong is known for a place where people from different cultures and ethnicities meet and inhabit (Flowerdew, 2012). The use of *Hongkonger** helps to conceptualize people from Hong Kong as a homogeneous group, which has a separate identity from "Chinese" (DeGolyer, 1997). However, our interview of some native English speakers finds that they cannot tell the differences between the two labels *Hongkonger** and *Hong Kong people**. As Caldas-Coulthard and Moon (2010) suggest, "media categorizes people through very specific points of view and values not always apparent to a non-critical reader" (p. 99). Therefore, it is worthy of further analysis in order to examine how they are used in SCMP. The labels *Hongkongese* and *Chinese Hong Kong resident* are rarely used, because the former, like *Chinese* and *Japanese*, implies that Hong Kong belongs to a special nationality, while the latter also downplays Hong Kong's unique status as a SAR of China.

The presence of different labels in SCMP can be attributed to the need to incorporate different voices in news reporting. It further demonstrates that news media serve as an important site of ideological struggles (Fairclough, 1995). As a local English newspaper, SCMP still features the overt preference for the labels which underline the local or unique identity of Hong Kong, but it also shows the use of some labels which suggest varied degrees of national identification. As a quality English newspaper, it also refrains from using these contentious labels which either downgrades (e.g., *Chinese Hong Kong*) or upgrades (e.g., *Hongkongese*) the unique status of Hong Kong. It can be attributed to the dual need of SCMP to address the local concerns and align with the "one China" policy. Additionally, a predominant label has been identified for people from the Chinese mainland (i.e., *mainlander**), two competing labels for people from Hong Kong (i.e., *Hong Kong people** and *Hongkonger**), but there is still little knowledge about how they are used over the twenty years.

5.2. The diachronic distribution of identity labels

This section gives a diachronic analysis of the distribution of these identity labels in SCMP over the twenty years. The primary purpose is to investigate how these identity labels vary with different socio-political contexts and draw attention to "those incidents wherein a label becomes dominant and results in a prescription of meaning" (Ancut and Mahadevan, 2017, p. 16).

Fig. 1 shows the distribution of labels for Hong Kong during the twenty years. The frequencies of *Hong Kong** were relatively stable during the twenty years. This is because all news texts collected in the corpus are about Hong Kong. However, the use of the official label *SAR**, though relatively stable in the first five years, has ceased abruptly since 2003. It suggests that SCMP tended to dis-align with the Chinese government in its reference to Hong Kong after 2003. This can be attributed to the breakout of the mass demonstration against the legislation of the National Security Ordinance in 2003. Therefore, the attempt to legislate the Article-23 in 2003 resulted in the disregard of the Chief Executive Tung Chee-haw's promotion of a common Chinese identity (Flowerdew et al., 2002) and the revival of the adherence to a distinct Hong Kong identity (Cheng, 2005).

Similar finding can also be made in the use of identity labels for people from Hong Kong (see Fig. 2). Before 2003, *Hongkonger** was rarely used. However, the following years showed a rising trend in the use of *Hongkonger**, which reached its prime in the years from 2012 to 2015. The use of *Hong Kong people**, however, showed an opposite trend, which rose in the first seven years (1998–2004) but declined in the following years. *Hongkonger** has gradually replaced *Hong Kong people** as the dominant label for people from Hong Kong. The growing use of the lexicalized label *Hongkonger** after 2003 can be attributed to the increasing adherence to the distinct Hong Kong identity. It suggests that SCMP still aligned with the local residents in construction of Hong Kong identity in spite of the "honeymoon" phase in the relations between Hong Kong and China during the years from 2004 to 2009 (Veg, 2017). Besides, the increasing use of the label *local** in the last five years also suggests the rise of localism in recent years (Veg, 2017). Especially in 2012, the use of *Hongkonger** hit a historical high, which can be attributed to the resistance movement against plans for national education in secondary schools in 2012 (Veg, 2017). This is consistent with the finding that the percentage of those who identify themselves as Hongkongers was at a historical high in 2012 (Yew and Kwong, 2014). However, after 2015, the use of *Hongkonger** shows a sharp decline. It is still hard to tell whether it can be attributed to the ownership change of SCMP or the ease of tensions in Hong Kong in view of the fact that SCMP was sold to the business tycoon Jack Ma from Chinese mainland in 2015.

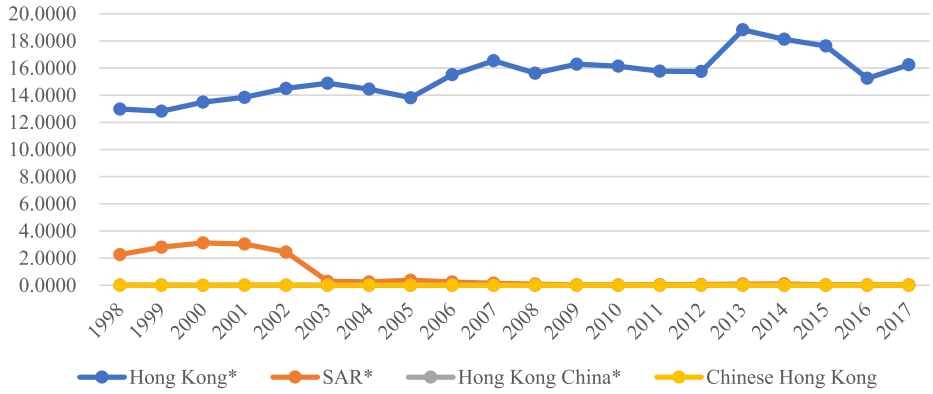


Fig. 1. Distribution of labels for Hong Kong.

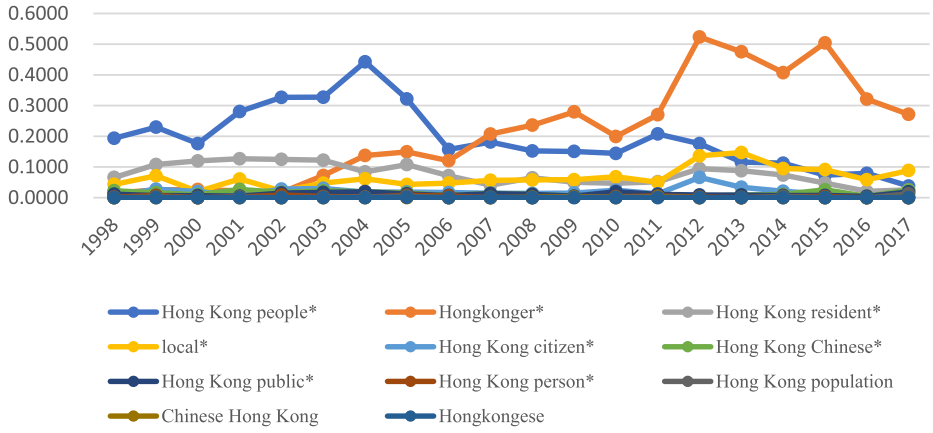


Fig. 2. Distribution of the referential expressions for people in Hong Kong.

Fig. 3 shows the distribution of identity labels for people from the Chinese mainland. It shows that *mainlander** was not frequently used in 1998, but it was increasingly used in the following years, and reached its first peak in 2002, which can be attributed to the growing conflict between visitors from Chinese mainland and people from Hong Kong in the first five years after Hong Kong's return (Fung and Chan, 2017). However, the following years from 2003 to 2011 showed a relatively stable trend in the use of *mainlander**. This is because this period represents a "honeymoon" phase in China-Hong Kong relationships during which Hong Kong people refuse to view mainlanders as "the cultural other" (Fung and Chan, 2017, p. 5). Hong Kong has recovered from its economic slump, due to the introduction of IVS in 2003 and the growing number of mainlanders visiting Hong Kong. However, *mainlander** was used much more frequently in the years from 2012 to 2015 than in previous years. This can be attributed to the growing conflicts between Hong Kong and China in this period. Therefore, the use of the label *mainlander** varies with the relations between Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland. Besides, like *Hongkonger**, *mainlander** also shows a dramatic decline in its use after 2015. Like mentioned above, the reasons for this still cannot be decided.

Above all, there are two critical years in SCMP's representations of Hong Kong, i.e., 2003 and 2012. They are the years in which the Chinese government took the initiative to take some proactive measures to strength the solidarity between China and Hong Kong, i.e., the legislation of Article-23 in 2003 and the change of national education curriculum in 2012. The use of identity labels, therefore, is sensitive to the pressure from the Chinese government, and the choice of some identity labels can be viewed as a resistant strategy to the Chinese government. However, as Caldas-Coulthard and Moon (2010) suggest, while simple comparisons of the frequencies of these identity labels are interesting, it is more important to examine their usage in context and their associated meanings. The following sections give a close examination of the specific uses of these identity labels.

5.3. Discursive constructions of people from Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland

This section gives a close analysis of three most frequently used labels for people from Hong Kong and Chinese mainland, i.e., *mainlanders**, *Hong Kong people**, and *Honkongers**. It focuses on the most frequently used tokens for each identity label, i.e., *mainlanders* (1358), *Hong Kong people* (1906), and *Hongkongers* (1749).

5.3.1. Analysis of actions associated with the three identity labels

These lexical verb collocates have been further identified and classified into three categories based on the transitivity analysis in systemic functional grammar: (1) verbal process verbs, (2) mental process verbs, and (3) material process verbs (Fowler, 1991; Halliday, 1994). Verbal process verbs express the meaning of "saying", mental process verbs describing mental activities; material process verbs expressing the meaning of "doing" (Halliday, 1994). There are 24 lexical verb collocates identified for both *mainlanders* and *Hong Kong people* and 23 for *Hongkongers* (see Table 2). The words in boldface show lexical verb collocates which can be identified for both *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers*. They are considered as consistent collocates of people from Hong Kong.

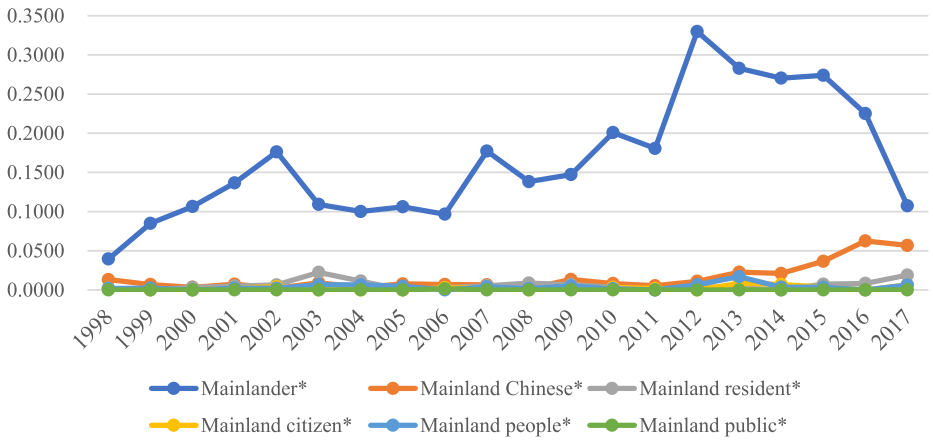


Fig. 3. Distribution of the referential expressions for people in Chinese mainland.

Table 2
Lexical verb collocates of the three lexical items.

Types	*Mainlanders*	*Hong Kong People*	*Hongkongers*
Verbal	*said* (98)	***said*** (1 7 6), *say* (18), ***urged*** (15)	***said*** (1 1 3), *called* (19), ***urged*** (17)
Mental	*allow* (35), *allowed* (24), *allowing* (15)	*know* (32), ***think*** (31), ***want*** (26), ***see*** (22), ***feel*** (19), *believe* (18), ***found*** (16), *care* (16)	***think*** (19), ***see*** (15), ***found*** (15), ***feel*** (14), ***want*** (12),
Material	*invest* (36), *visit* (36), *travel* (25), *buy* (23), *buying* (22), *bought* (20), *visiting* (18), *come* (17), *spending* (17), *coming* (16), *give* (16), *arrested* (14), *seeking* (14), *shopping* (14), *giving* (12), *growing* (12), *visited* (12)	***working*** (29), ***take*** (29), *ruling* (28), ***living*** (27), ***help*** (24), ***work*** (22), ***show*** (17), *missing* (16), *live* (16), *use* (14), ***give*** (14)	***help*** (26), ***working*** (17), ***living*** (19), ***work*** (15), ***show*** (14), *arrested* (14), ***take*** (13), ***showed*** (12), *put* (12), *killed* (12), *visiting* (11), *visited* (11), *given* (11)

They suggest that *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers* are used in similar contexts.

While all the three lexical items collocate frequently with material process verbs, *Hongkongers* and *Hong Kong people* collocate more frequently with mental process verbs than *mainlanders*. Both *Hongkongers* and *Hong Kong people* collocate frequently with mental process verbs like *think*, *want*, *feel*, *see*, and *found*. However, *mainlanders* only collocates with three tokens of mental process verb, i.e., *allow*, *allowed*, and *allowing*. They emphasize the meaning of giving permission, and mainlanders always serve as the object of mental activities in these concordance lines, suggesting that mainlanders do not have the rights to do something, as in the following:

(1) The move could *allow* mainlanders living in Hong Kong to visit Taiwan as tourists for the first time.

In other words, SCMP shows more concerns over the mental activities of people from Hong Kong than the mental activities of mainlanders.

With regard to material process verbs, those of *mainlanders* emphasize mainlanders investing, visiting, shopping, travelling, and giving birth in Hong Kong. They constructed mainlanders as either contributors to Hong Kong's economy or troublemakers for Hong Kong's public services. However, both *Hongkongers* and *Hong Kong people* collocate frequently with material process verbs like *working*, *living*, *work*, *help*, and *show*. People in Hong Kong either serve as the actors of the intransitive verbs (i.e., *working*, *living*, *work*) and the goal of the transitive verbs (i.e., *help* and *show*), as in the following:

(2) Describing the local delegation as "a very important force which can *help* Hong Kong people understand more about the central government's policies", Mr. Qiao also said...

These verbs construct an active role for mainlanders but a passive role for Hong Kong people and Hongkongers. It can also be perceived in the use of verbal process verbs. While the three lexical items collocate frequently with *said*, *Hongkongers* and *Hong Kong people* also collocate frequently with *urged*. They express the request for Hong Kong people to do something, as in the following:

(3) Vice-president Zeng Qinghong yesterday *urged* Hong Kong people to grasp the timely opportunity to develop the economy.

The passive representations of people from Hong Kong and the active representations of mainlanders further suggest the newspaper's alignment with Hong Kong people, because they help to construct people from Hong Kong as innocent victims and mainlanders as troublemakers.

Nevertheless, *Hongkongers* carries a more negative semantic prosody than *Hong Kong people*. While *Hong Kong people* is used to emphasize the official policy of "Hong Kong people ruling Hong Kong" (see the collocate *ruling*), *Hongkongers* is rarely used to express "Hongkongers ruling Hong Kong". Instead, *Hongkongers* collocates frequently with *killed* and *arrested*, which emphasize Hongkongers who are killed and arrested. Besides, *Hong Kong people* also collocates frequently with mental process verbs *know*, *believe*, and *care*, they highlight the congenial mental status of Hong Kong people. Furthermore, *Hongkongers* collocates more frequently with the verbs expressing request, since the collocate *called* here is part of the verb phrase *called on*. It indicates that Hongkongers are less active than Hong Kong people.

5.3.2. Analysis of attributes associates with the three identity labels

This section examines both attributive and predicative adjectives of the three lexical items. According to Taylor (2003),

"attributive adjectives tend to characterize a thing in terms of a stable, inherent property, whereas predicative adjectives tend to denote more temporary, circumstantial properties" (p. 455). For example, "the rude man" and "the man is rude" are different, because rudeness is considered as an inherent property of the man in the former phrase but a temporal and transient property of the man in the latter sentence. Caldas-Coulthard and Moon (2010) point out that the nominal group "(PREMODIFIER + NOUN)" is important, because it is "an economical way of packaging information, representing what writers consider relevant and interesting, as well as reflecting values and stereotypes consistent with the publication's ideology" (p. 110). The attributive adjectives can be revealed through a close examination of the adjectives following the pattern "NOUN + *are*", because they are a typical way of assigning a certain property to a group.

The adjective collocates occurring at the L1 position of the three lexical items are listed as follows:

- ***Mainlanders***: *pregnant* (26), *rich* (11), *affluent* (6), *talented* (6), *young* (6), *wealthy* (6), *visiting* (4), *mighty* (2), *educated* (2), *ordinary* (2), *well-educated* (1), *expectant* (1), *overstaying* (1), *deep-pocketed* (1), *prosperous* (1), *well-to-do* (1), *resourceful* (1), *sophisticated* (1), *free-spending* (1), and *big-spending* (1).
- ***Hong Kong people***: *ordinary* (4), *local* (3), *young* (3), *healthy* (2), *influential* (2), *prominent* (1), *stylish* (1), *quick-witted* (1), *money-minded* (1), and *hard-working* (1)
- ***Hongkongers***: *young* (23), *elderly* (9), *fellow* (4), *wealthy* (4), *angry* (2), *local* (2), *older* (2), *ordinary* (2), and *true* (2)

More adjective premodifiers have been identified for *mainlanders* than for *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers*. It indicates that SCMP is more eager to assign some inherent properties to *mainlanders* than to *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers*. The majority of these attributive adjectives before *mainlanders* primarily highlight mainlanders who are rich and free-spending, such as *rich*, *affluent*, *wealthy*, *well-to-do*, *deep-pocketed*, *prosperous*, *free-spending*, and *big-spending*. Some other adjectives also highlight mainlanders who are pregnant, i.e., *pregnant* and *expectant*. As mentioned above, they emphasize expectant mothers coming to give birth in Hong Kong and bring troubles to Hong Kong people. However, these attributive adjectives carry a negative semantic prosody, including *resourceful*, *sophisticated*, *free-spending*, and *big-spending*. They appear before identity labels, taken as inherent attributes of mainlanders. They help to produce and reproduce stereotypes towards mainlanders. Examples are as follows:

(4) *Resourceful* mainlanders have invented a myriad of more sophisticated ways to circumvent official capital-account restrictions.
(5) Hong Kong loses some 'golden week' allure 'More *sophisticated*' mainlanders taking other holiday options

Attributive adjectives before *Hong Kong people* tend to highlight Hong Kong people with different social statuses, including *ordinary*, *influential*, and *prominent*. They tend to be positively evaluated as *stylish*, *quick-witted*, *money-minded*, and *hard-working*, which are in contrast to the negative attributes of mainlanders, such as *resourceful*, *sophisticated*, *free-spending*, and *big-spending*. By contrast, attributive adjectives before *Hongkongers* tend to highlight Hongkongers in different age groups, including *young*, *elderly*, and *older*. In particular, *young* has become the most frequent attributive adjective before *Hongkongers*, suggesting that young Hongkongers have emerged as a prominent group in Hong Kong. Besides, the adjective *angry* also emphasize Hongkongers who are dissatisfied, and the adjective *true* points to the question of who are Hongkongers.

The exact occurrences of *are* at the R1 position (the first position to the right) of the three lexical items are 53 for *mainlanders*, 220 for *Hong Kong people*, and 118 for *Hongkongers*. However, the number of concordance lines describing the attributes of these lexical items is 25 for *mainlanders*, 166 for *Hong Kong people*, and 68 for *Hongkongers*. Therefore, more predicative adjectives are used for *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers* than for *mainlanders*. This is consistent with the finding of the use of predicate adjectives. It suggests that SCMP prefers to assign inherent attributes to "Other" and transient attributes to "Us".

Besides, the attributes following *mainlanders are* highlight that mainlanders are becoming richer and richer and interested in buying and investing in Hong Kong, as in the following:

we have done it before. But this time, the **mainlanders** are far savvier about the world of international finance.
percent in the same period last year. As **mainlanders** are becoming wealthier and know more about the world,
benefit because it is already a market that **mainlanders** are very familiar with and it is also very close to
prices are going up, he declared, because **mainlanders** are getting richer, and so are competing with Hong
the majority of buyers were Hongkongers. **Mainlanders** are getting richer and are more interested in new
reached amid strong demand, only a handful of **mainlanders** are interested in buying H shares Hong Kong
new luxury tower in Hunghom, quite a few **mainlanders** are interested in investing in their southern neighbour.
a unit of Sun Hung Kai Properties, also agrees **mainlanders** are still keen on Hong Kong luxury homes. Lui

However, *Hong Kong people are* tends to carry a positive semantic prosody. They emphasize that Hong Kong people are satisfied with the status quo and unconcerned about politics. They are hardworking, pragmatic, money-minded, but also willing to help. Examples are as follows:

in America tend to be much more outgoing. In **Hong Kong people** are not so outgoing, but I think they
("Brat in the family", November 9) said that **Hong Kong people** are not patriotic towards their motherland.
deterred Hong Kong people from visiting Japan. "**Hong Kong people** are not [overly] political," he said. In
after bus hijacking More than 60 per cent of **Hong Kong people** are satisfied with the performance of local med
Japan . . . we start to feel lucky. That is why **Hong Kong people** are still happy despite social problems and eco
especially as we did it in a short time. "**Hong Kong people** are industrious and there's a good generation
who ran in the half marathon on Sunday. **Hong Kong people** are very generous and always quick to be
Mr Tung's leadership is very strong. I feel that **Hong Kong people** are very rational, have the highest respect

However, *Hongkongers are* tend to carry a negative semantic prosody. They emphasize that Hongkongers are dissatisfied with the status quo and concerned about the future. Examples are as follows:

British colonialists. And until now, you **[Hongkongers]** are still dogs. You aren't human. The fiery professor
River Delta for the long term. "Many **Hongkongers** are worried that Hong Kong will become marginalised.
yesterday. The article, entitled "Why **Hongkongers** are furious", said eating was not allowed on MTR trains
but ... cry and tell Mr Tung, "I'm afraid **Hongkongers** are doomed under their own hands in future." Mr Tung
all round as HK slips in happiness index **Hongkongers** are getting less happy by the year, with the city
prices in the city currently at a record high, **Hongkongers** are worried that a new slowdown will trigger a
suffrage. It is an insult to suggest that **Hongkongers** are political dupes, yet this is a well-worn inference

Therefore, the three labels vary not only in the properties they are associated with but also the ways they are evaluated. SCMP shows an ambivalence in the constructions of mainlanders: while emphasizing mainlanders as wealthy, they also underline their inherent negative attributes, such as resourceful, sophisticated, and free-spending. They are in contrast to the positive attributes associated with *Hong Kong people*, such as quick-witted, pragmatic, money-minded, and hardworking. While *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers* share some common features, the constructions of *Hongkongers* tend to be more negative than *Hong Kong people*. SCMP prefers to use attributive adjectives to describe *mainlanders* but predicative adjectives to describe *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers*. In so doing, it constructs these negative properties of *mainlanders* as given knowledge shared between people in Hong Kong, and the properties of *Hong Kong people* and *Hongkongers* as propositions which are negotiable. Besides, *Hongkongers* tends to carry a more negative semantic prosody than *Hong Kong people*. The shift from *Hong Kong people* to *Hongkongers* can be regarded as a discursive strategy in response to the growing conflicts between Hong Kong and the Chinse mainland, because it consolidates the local identity of people in Hong Kong.

6. Conclusion

This study has given a close examination of three groups of identity labels key to the construction of Hong Kong identity in SCMP during the last two decades. It further demonstrates that identity labels serve an important site for ideological struggles in identity constructions, and each label carries its own implicature about the relations between Hong Kong and China. While the presence of different identity labels can be attributed to the news writers' personal choices or the necessity to incorporate different or even competing voices in presenting more or less "balanced" news reporting (Kuosmanen, 2019), the overall preference for different identify labels can shed light on the newspaper's ideological stance and its role in the construction of Hong Kong identity (Zhang and Mihelj, 2012). Although SCMP also uses some labels which suggest varied degrees of national identification after Hong Kong's return to China in 1997, it still shows the dominant preference for the labels which highlight Hong Kong's local identity. Nevertheless, as a quality English newspaper, SCMP also refrains from using these contentious labels which might challenge the "One China" principle and the Chinese government. While the general ideological framework of positive self-presentation and negative other-presentation is still at work in SCMP's representations of people from Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland (van Dijk, 1998; Wodak et al., 2009), the choice of identity labels for people from Hong Kong is inconsistent and subject to the influences of changing socio-political contexts. The decline in the use of SAR* and the transfer from *Hong Kong people* to *Hongkongers* can be attributed to the growing awareness of local identity and the interventionist approach adopted by the Chinese government since 2003 (Yew and Kwong, 2014). Overall, the representations of people from Hong Kong has become increasingly conflictual, especially in the years from 2012 to 2015. This might provide some insights into the role of news media in the growing conflicts between Hong Kong and Chinese mainland and the mass protests against the proposed extradition bill in 2019.

This study has further demonstrated the value of CADS to the study of identity labels (Zhang and Mihelj, 2012). While the choice of a single identity label might be out of a certain news reporter's personal preference or the necessity to cite a particular news source, the availability of a large corpus can present both a wholistic picture of the different identity labels used and a newspaper's preference to these labels, thus pointing to the "cumulative effects" of identity labels in news discourse (Fairclough, 1989). Meanwhile, a diachronic analysis of these identity labels in a large corpus can further reveal how a certain newspaper interacts with the changing socio-political contexts (Partington, 2010). Therefore, a combination of the methods and theories associated with CL and CDA can not only present an efficient means to the identification and analysis of identity labels in a large corpus but, more importantly, expose the intricate relations between the use of identity labels and changing socio-political contexts (Baker et al., 2008). Nevertheless, it will be more illuminating in future studies to give a close examination of whether these identity labels are used/translated by the news writers themselves or attributed to some external sources. Further diachronic studies are also required to examine the influences of the ownership change in 2015 on the use of identity labels in SCMP in view of the decline in the use of some identity labels after 2015.

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